

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

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DOMINANT JUDGMENT	TWO TRIGGERS, ONE WINDOW

Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

Executive Warning: Two simultaneous geopolitical triggers elevated the cyber threat environment for Texas critical infrastructure this week. Iran's IRGC struck the Singapore-flagged container ship *Ever Lovely* in the Strait of Hormuz on June 25 — the most serious test yet of the fragile U.S.-Iran ceasefire — and the U.S. responded with retaliatory military strikes on June 26. Russia is simultaneously absorbing the worst fuel crisis since the 2014 annexation of Crimea, with Ukrainian drone strikes taking more than 20 percent of Russian refining capacity offline. Both adversaries now carry fresh operational incentives for deniable cyber activity against Western energy, logistics, and infrastructure targets. **No confirmed cyber incident targeting Texas infrastructure was identified this week.** This brief assesses elevated probability of adversary action in the near term based on confirmed pre-existing campaigns and live geopolitical triggers — not on a Texas incident that has already occurred.

Board Implication — Iran

The April CISA/FBI/NSA/EPA/DOE joint advisory confirmed IRGC actors are actively exploiting internet-exposed PLCs and HMIs across U.S. energy and water sectors. That campaign predates June 25. The Hormuz exchange raises the probability it accelerates. Texas OT operators who have not audited internet-facing exposure since April have a known gap.

Board Implication — Russia

Ukraine's strike campaign has produced the worst Russian domestic fuel crisis since 2014 — IEA confirmed “unprecedented” disruption. Sandworm's 2015–2016 Ukraine grid attacks established the historical pattern: strategic pressure correlates with expanded state-authorized cyber operations. Texas LNG and refining infrastructure carry symbolic and operational relevance to Moscow.

Board Implication — Governance

Two San Antonio healthcare providers face class-action suits after notification delays following ransomware claims. Alamo Heights ISD disclosed 26,629 people exposed from a March attack. In both cases the governance failure — unclear decision authority, delayed notification, incomplete evidence preservation — is the executive liability, not the breach itself.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

HIGH CONFIDENCE — Confirmed active campaign: Iranian-affiliated cyber actors have been exploiting internet-exposed PLCs and HMIs across U.S. energy, water, and government sectors since at least March 2026. Six federal agencies — CISA, FBI, NSA, EPA, DOE, and U.S. Cyber Command — documented this in a joint advisory on April 7, 2026, with confirmed operational disruptions and financial losses. The IRGC-CEC group (CyberAv3ngers) is the confirmed actor. Texas energy, water, and industrial operators with internet-facing OT devices sit inside this confirmed target set. This advisory has not been rescinded.

MODERATE CONFIDENCE — Assessed acceleration risk: The June 25–26 Hormuz exchange materially increased the probability that this existing campaign accelerates or expands against U.S. targets in the near term. Iran's parliament publicly framed the *Ever Lovely* strike as “ceasefire management” — not a violation — lowering its perceived cost of continued action. Historical pattern: Iran has used CyberAv3ngers and proxy collectives for deniable disruption operations during prior periods of kinetic escalation. Primary uncertainty: whether Tehran chooses acceleration, new proxy campaigns, or restraint pending negotiation.

Russia adds a second pressure vector. Ukraine's campaign produced the worst Russian fuel crisis since 2014 — IEA confirmed more than 20 percent of refining capacity offline; 55 of 83 federal regions under mandatory fuel rationing; civilian gasoline sales suspended in Crimea. This level of domestic economic pressure is historically correlated with expanded state-authorized cyber activity. Sandworm (GRU/APT44) launched its December 2015 and December 2016 Ukraine grid attacks during comparable periods of Russian strategic stress, coordinating kinetic and cyber operations against critical infrastructure. Amazon Threat Intelligence confirmed in late 2025 that Sandworm has pivoted toward misconfigured network edge devices as its primary initial access vector against U.S. and European critical infrastructure — lowering the technical barrier for new targeting.

The decision-timing gap is the executive exposure. In both adversary threat streams and in both Texas governance failures this week, the determinative window is not the attack — it is the interval between event and authorized response. Executives who have not pre-assigned breach determination, notification, isolation, and communications authority are not unprepared for the technical incident; they are unprepared for the decision that follows it.

Section I

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Iranian-affiliated cyber actors are **confirmed** exploiting internet-exposed PLCs and HMIs across U.S. critical infrastructure — and the June 25 Hormuz exchange is **likely** to accelerate that campaign in the near term. **HIGH CONFIDENCE — Active Campaign / MODERATE CONFIDENCE — Acceleration Assessment**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis (HIGH tier): CISA/FBI/NSA/EPA/DOE/CNMF joint advisory AA26-097A, April 7, 2026. Six-agency confirmation of IRGC-CEC activity with confirmed operational disruptions. Source basis (MODERATE tier): NPR, Fox News/Reuters, CENTCOM statements, June 26–27, 2026. Iranian parliamentary statements on Hormuz. Primary uncertainty: Tehran's choice of acceleration, proxy activity, or restraint is unconfirmed.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas energy, water, and industrial operators with internet-facing OT devices should treat the April advisory as current — not historical — and validate exposure against it this week.

KJ-2

Russia's domestic fuel crisis is **assessed** at a severity historically correlated with expanded state-authorized cyber activity against Western energy and logistics targets. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: RFE/RL June 24, 2026 (55 of 83 regions rationing; IEA "unprecedented" quote); NPR/Euronews/Al Jazeera June 21, 2026 (Crimea suspension confirmed); Sandworm 2015–2016 grid attack historical record (MITRE ATT&CK G0034; Wikipedia/Mandiant/Dragos). Amazon Threat Intelligence (late 2025) confirms Sandworm pivot to misconfigured edge devices. Primary uncertainty: no confirmed new Sandworm or GRU-linked targeting of U.S. critical infrastructure identified this week.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas LNG, refining, DIB, and logistics operators should review third-party access, edge-device exposure, and supplier communications channels for anomalies — not only known Russian IP ranges or malware signatures.

KJ-3

Texas healthcare and public-sector organizations face **confirmed** executive litigation and regulatory exposure from ransomware disclosure governance failures — independent of adversary nation-state activity. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Texas AG breach notification filing, June 23, 2026 (AHISD, 26,629 individuals); classaction.org/Digital Forensics Magazine, June 25–26, 2026 (South Texas Spinal Clinic and Soniva Dental lawsuit filings). Limitation: lawsuit allegations are unconfirmed findings. Breach scope for South Texas Spinal Clinic unconfirmed by the organization as of June 15.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Healthcare boards should confirm this week who owns breach determination, notification authority, evidence preservation, and public communications — before those decisions are forced by an active incident.

Section II

What Changed This Week

Iran — Hormuz Exchange Creates Live Retaliation Trigger

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

On June 25, Iran's IRGC launched four drones at ships in the Strait of Hormuz; one struck the Singapore-flagged *Ever Lovely* on the upper deck. The U.S. intercepted three drones and, on June 26, CENTCOM conducted retaliatory strikes on Iranian missile and drone storage infrastructure near the strait and Qeshm Island. The International Maritime Organization immediately halted its 11,000-sailor ship evacuation operation. Approximately 500 ships remain in the strait area. Daily transits had reached 78 vessels on June 24 — the highest since the conflict began — before the attack. Iran's parliament publicly characterized the strike as "ceasefire management, not violation." This framing signals intent to continue testing the framework without accepting accountability for escalation.

What this changes for cyber: Iran already has an active PLC/HMI exploitation campaign against U.S. energy and water infrastructure (CISA AA26-097A, April 7, 2026). The June 25 kinetic action raises the probability of campaign acceleration — not initiation. The window between geopolitical trigger and cyber activity, based on the 2026 IRGC campaign pattern, is days to weeks.

Russia — Fuel Crisis Reaches Unprecedented Severity**CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING**

Ukrainian drone strikes have knocked more than 20 percent of Russia's total refining capacity offline, with more than two dozen strikes against refineries since March 2026 — including eight of the ten largest. The Kapotnya refinery, Moscow's primary regional supplier, was struck twice and is offline through at least end of 2026. As of June 24, 55 of Russia's 83 federal regions reported mandatory fuel rationing. Civilian gasoline sales in Crimea were fully suspended June 21. The IEA called the disruption "unprecedented in the history of the Russia-Ukraine conflict." Russia's Kremlin publicly acknowledged the crisis — a rare admission — while Russian military bloggers criticized the failure to anticipate the campaign.

What this changes for cyber: This level of domestic pressure — public acknowledgment, military criticism, tourism disruption at peak season — historically correlates with Kremlin authorization of expanded deniable cyber activity as a pressure-release and signaling mechanism. The 2015–2016 Sandworm Ukraine grid attacks occurred under comparable strategic stress. Texas LNG export infrastructure is directly relevant to the energy competition dynamic.

Texas — Healthcare Ransomware Litigation and ISD Breach Disclosure**CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING**

Two San Antonio healthcare providers — South Texas Spinal Clinic PA and Soniva Dental — are facing proposed class-action lawsuits alleging inadequate data safeguarding and delayed notification following ransomware claims by "the Gentlemen" group in June. Separately, Alamo Heights ISD filed with the Texas AG on June 23, confirming its March cyberattack exposed 26,629 individuals — Social Security numbers, driver's license numbers, financial account data, and medical information. District cyber insurance covered more than \$36,000 in restoration costs. The district did not confirm whether a ransom was paid. Texas law requires government entities to report breaches affecting 250 or more residents within 30 days of discovery — the March-to-June gap in this case reflects the forensic investigation timeline, not a filing failure.

Section III

Cross-Sector Implications

Energy OT / LNG / Refining / Water	The April 7 CISA joint advisory confirmed IRGC-affiliated actors are actively exploiting internet-exposed PLCs and HMIs in U.S. energy, water, and government sectors — with configuration wiping, HMI manipulation, and sensor tampering producing confirmed operational disruptions and financial losses. Texas refining, LNG, and water utility operators that have not audited internet-facing OT exposure since that advisory have left a known attack surface open for more than two months, and the Hormuz exchange provides fresh adversary incentive to use it. The action this week is operational, not conceptual: inventory internet-exposed PLCs, HMIs, and SCADA interfaces; segment them; validate that emergency isolation authority is pre-approved at the operational level — not requiring a board meeting to execute. The decision to disconnect must happen before the claim appears online, not after.
Finance Energy Markets / Maritime Insurance / Liquidity	Texas financial institutions are not the primary direct target in either the Iranian or Russian threat stream this week. The exposure is structural and cascading. Hormuz shipping disruption — approximately 500 ships still in the area, IMO evacuation halted — creates downstream commodity price volatility and payment-flow uncertainty across Texas energy, LNG, and maritime insurance markets. Prolonged Strait friction translates into counterparty risk and liquidity stress for Texas firms with energy and logistics exposure. A regional energy infrastructure disruption event, whether cyber-triggered or kinetic-adjacent, will simultaneously drive insurance claims, liquidity pressure, and business continuity failures. Finance executives should confirm this week that operational continuity plans address a regional energy disruption scenario — not only a direct cyber incident against their own systems.
Healthcare & DIB Ransomware / Governance / Disclosure	This week's San Antonio cases demonstrate the same structural failure pattern: when breach determination authority, notification sequencing, evidence preservation, and public communications ownership are undefined before an event, the 72-hour window after discovery becomes the liability, not the breach itself. South Texas Spinal Clinic and Soniva Dental now face class-action exposure for notification delay. Alamo Heights ISD disclosed 26,629 individuals affected from a March attack — a three-month forensic timeline that is legally defensible but exposes the gap between incident and public accountability. For DIB: Russian logistics pressure and Iranian targeting of government and industrial systems make this a period of elevated collection risk for Texas defense suppliers. Revalidate third-party access and privileged vendor credentials this week.

Section IV

Indicators & Warnings — PIR Watch, 1 to 4 Weeks

PIR 1 / I&W 1 Iranian proxy or hacktivist claims targeting U.S. energy, water, or port infrastructure [↑ Rising]

→ Watch for CyberAv3ngers, Handala Hack, or unnamed IRGC-affiliated groups claiming disruption operations against U.S. critical infrastructure — particularly water utilities, energy control systems, LNG terminals, or port operations.

→ Any confirmed claim within the next two to four weeks would indicate the June 25 kinetic trigger accelerated the existing OT campaign rather than sustaining it at current tempo. This is the primary escalation signal for the MODERATE confidence tier of KJ-1.

→ Tied to: PIR 1, PIR 3, PIR 5 — adversary intent, geopolitical trigger, and sector disruption indicators.

PIR 4 / I&W 2 New CISA KEV entries or emergency directives targeting OT/ICS device categories [**↑ Rising**]

→ Watch for CISA adding OT-adjacent vulnerabilities to the Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog beyond the April PLC advisory — particularly new device categories in energy or water sectors.

→ Expansion into additional device types would confirm the Iranian campaign is broadening its target set beyond the Rockwell Automation PLC footprint established in April. An emergency directive targeting ICS devices would signal confirmed active exploitation at a new severity threshold.

→ Tied to: PIR 4, PIR 5 — vulnerability exploitation cadence and sector-specific risk indicators.

PIR 1 / I&W 3 Sandworm-attributed or Russian-aligned hacktivist claims against Western energy or logistics targets [**↑ Rising**]

→ Watch for Sandworm (APT44/GRU Unit 74455), NoName057(16), or similar Russian-aligned groups claiming or conducting disruption operations against European or U.S. energy, refinery, port, or logistics targets.

→ Ukraine's campaign is producing the worst Russian domestic fuel pressure in over a decade. The 2015–2016 Sandworm precedent established that this level of strategic stress correlates with expanded state-authorized cyber operations against infrastructure. Sandworm's current edge-device pivot (confirmed by Amazon Threat Intelligence, late 2025) lowers the technical barrier for new U.S. or European targeting.

→ Tied to: PIR 1, PIR 3 — Russian adversary intent and geopolitical escalation indicators.

PIR 2 / I&W 4 Texas AG breach notification filings from healthcare or public-sector entities [**↑ Rising**]

→ Watch for additional Texas healthcare, education, or municipal breach notifications filed with the Texas AG or HHS within the next 30 days. Texas law requires government bodies to report breaches affecting 250 or more residents within 30 days of discovery.

→ A cluster of new filings would confirm that under-resourced Texas public-service organizations are under sustained targeting — and that the litigation pattern demonstrated this week is expanding beyond isolated cases into a sector-wide governance exposure.

→ Tied to: PIR 2, PIR 6 — Texas sector disruption signals and governance risk indicators.

PIR 3 / I&W 5 U.S.-Iran ceasefire framework deterioration — confidence upgrade threshold [**→ Sustained**]

→ Watch for Iranian parliamentary statements hardening the “ceasefire management” framing, additional IRGC maritime actions in the Strait of Hormuz, or U.S. military posture changes in the region beyond June 26 retaliatory strikes.

→ This is a threshold indicator: if the ceasefire framework collapses or U.S.-Iran exchanges escalate beyond the current single exchange, the MODERATE confidence tier in KJ-1 upgrades to HIGH and client notification protocols activate.

→ Tied to: PIR 3, PIR 7 — geopolitical escalation and adversary decision-cycle indicators.

Section V

Governance Implication Block

Decision at risk	Whether your organization has pre-assigned ownership over the four decisions that determine legal and operational exposure after a cyber incident: breach determination, regulatory notification, evidence preservation, and public communications authority. This week's Texas cases demonstrated that technical recovery is not the primary governance failure. The failure is the absence of pre-assigned decision authority before the event — and the resulting loss of the 72-hour window that determines litigation posture, insurance coverage, and regulatory standing.
Owner	CEO, CISO, General Counsel, COO, and Privacy Officer. CFO ownership is required where cyber insurance coordination, ransomware payment authority, or financial disclosure thresholds are implicated. For OT environments: COO and operations leadership must hold isolation authority — this decision cannot route through IT alone.
Consequence of delay	Litigation before formal notification. Regulatory exposure from missed HIPAA, CIRCIA, or Texas breach notification deadlines. Insurance disputes from incomplete evidence chains. Board-level credibility loss when counsel asks who made the breach determination and the answer is unclear. For OT environments: an undocumented isolation decision — or failure to isolate — becomes a liability in any subsequent regulatory inquiry.
Action this week	Run a 60-minute tabletop with CEO, CISO, General Counsel, and COO on one scenario: a ransomware group has posted your organization's name on a dark-web leak site. No internal encryption has been confirmed. Who calls whom, in what order, and what is documented in the first 72 hours? For energy and water operators: add a second scenario where an OT vendor reports anomalous access to a PLC. Who has authority to isolate? What is the threshold? If those sequences are not rehearsed, the governance failure is already in place.
Record to preserve	Breach determination records and the timestamp of the decision. Ransom notes and dark-web claim captures. Firewall logs, OT exposure records, and vendor remote-access logs. Forensic image chain of custody. Insurer notice and outside counsel engagement records. All executive communications from discovery through first public statement. For OT: PLC and HMI configuration baselines, internet exposure records, and isolation decision authority documentation.

Section VI

Source Basis — ATB-2026-16

PRIMARY SOURCES — ATB-2026-16 — COVERAGE WEEK 21–27 JUNE 2026

GOVERNMENT

CISA/FBI/NSA/EPA/DOE/CNMF Joint Advisory AA26-097A — April 7, 2026

[ic3.gov/CSA/2026/260407.pdf](https://www.ic3.gov/CSA/2026/260407.pdf)

Six-agency confirmation of IRGC-CEC active exploitation of Rockwell Automation PLCs and HMIs in U.S. energy, water, and government sectors since at least March 2026. Confirms operational disruptions and financial losses. Primary source for HIGH confidence tier in KJ-1. Advisory remains active and unrescinded.

GOVERNMENT**EPA/FBI/CISA/NSA Joint Advisory — Water Sector Warning — April 7, 2026**[epa.gov — Iranian-Affiliated Cyber Actors Water Sector Advisory](https://www.epa.gov/iranian-affiliated-cyber-actors-water-sector-advisory)

Water sector-specific advisory confirming Iranian actors are disrupting U.S. drinking water and wastewater systems through configuration wiping, HMI manipulation, and sensor tampering. Names water sector as explicit target set for the OT exploitation campaign.

REGULATORY**Texas Attorney General Breach Notification Filing — Alamo Heights ISD — June 23, 2026**[ksat.com — Texas AG Confirms AHISD Breach](https://ksat.com/texas-ag-confirms-ahisd-breach/)

Confirmed 26,629 individuals affected. Data categories: Social Security numbers, driver's license numbers, financial account data, medical information. Cyber insurance recovery: \$36,000+. Breach occurred March 2026; notification via U.S. Mail. Cited for confirmed breach count, data scope, and notification timeline.

WIRE / MAJOR MEDIA**NPR — June 27, 2026 — U.S. Strikes Iran After Strait of Hormuz Drone Attack**[npr.org — U.S. Strikes Iran](https://www.npr.org/2026/06/27/us-strikes-iran/)

Confirms IMO evacuation suspension, pre-attack transit volume (78 vessels June 24), approximately 500 ships remaining in area, ceasefire framework context, and Iranian parliamentary framing of strike as "ceasefire management." Cyber implications are Liberty CTI assessment.

WIRE / MAJOR MEDIA**RFE/RL — June 24, 2026 — Russia Fuel Shortage Scope**[rferl.org — Russia Fuel Shortages](https://www.rferl.org/russia-fuel-shortages/)

Confirms 55 of 83 Russian federal regions under mandatory fuel restrictions as of June 24; more than 20 percent of refining capacity offline; Kapotnya refinery offline through end of 2026; IEA "unprecedented" characterization. Russian cyber implications are Liberty CTI assessment using Sandworm historical precedent.

WIRE / MAJOR MEDIA**NPR / Euronews / Al Jazeera — June 21, 2026 — Crimea Gasoline Suspension**[npr.org — Crimea Fuel Crisis](https://www.npr.org/2026/06/21/crimea-fuel-crisis/)

Confirms civilian gasoline sales suspended June 21 by Kremlin-appointed Aksyonov; four killed in overnight drone attacks; drone strike on Black Sea oil terminal in Chushka confirmed. Used for Russia fuel crisis severity assessment.

SECONDARY — LITIGATION REPORTING**Digital Forensics Magazine / classaction.org — June 25–26, 2026**[digitalforensicsmagazine.com — News Roundup June 26](https://digitalforensicsmagazine.com/news-roundup-june-26/)

Cited for litigation facts only. Confirms proposed class-action lawsuits against South Texas Spinal Clinic PA and Soniva Dental following Gentlemen ransomware group claims. Allegations are unconfirmed findings. South Texas Spinal Clinic had not confirmed the breach as of June 15, 2026.

SECONDARY — HISTORICAL PRECEDENT**Sandworm / APT44 Historical Record — MITRE ATT&CK G0034 / Mandiant / Dragos**[attack.mitre.org — Sandworm Group G0034](https://attack.mitre.org/sandworm-group-g0034/)

Cited for historical precedent only. Documents December 2015 BlackEnergy grid attack (230,000 Ukrainians without power) and December 2016 Industroyer/CRASHOVERRIDE Kyiv attack during periods of Russian strategic pressure. Used to support KJ-2 Russia pressure-to-cyber-activity correlation. Does not constitute confirmed new activity this week.

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

This week's brief applies the full Torch cycle. **WHAT:** Two simultaneous geopolitical triggers — Hormuz kinetic exchange and Russian fuel crisis — elevate adversary cyber retaliation incentive alongside a confirmed active Iranian OT exploitation campaign. **WHO:** Iranian IRGC-CEC (CyberAv3ngers) confirmed; Russian GRU/Sandworm assessed as elevated risk; financially motivated ransomware confirmed against Texas healthcare and education. **WHY:** Iran has a live retaliation trigger and an active PLC campaign. Russia is under unprecedented domestic fuel pressure with a documented history of translating strategic stress into cyber operations. Texas public-service organizations have demonstrated governance gaps that adversaries do not need to create — they only need to find. **WHAT NEXT:** Watch for ICS claim activity, new KEV entries in OT device categories, and additional Texas AG filings as the leading indicators of whether this week's geopolitical triggers translate into confirmed cyber events.

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